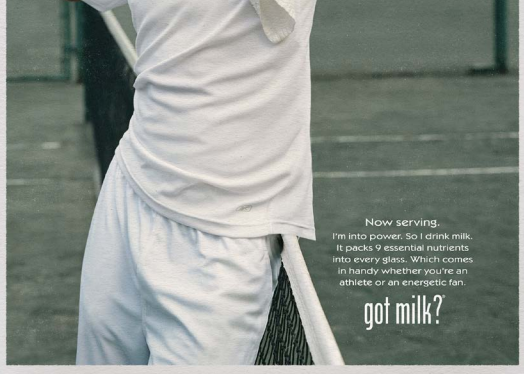
If you grew up in America between the 1950s and 1990s, you probably took for granted that milk was good for you. You may have drunk it with every meal: A bowl of cereal for breakfast. A half-pint carton on the cafeteria tray at lunch. A tall glass of milk to wash down dinner. By the early '90s, however, "good for you" was apparently not good enough. The USDA and the dairy industry were ringing the alarm bells: Milk consumption was declining, putting a billion-dollar industry at risk. So a clutch of new marketing groups, created by the government and funded by a flood of cash, took a new tack: advertising. Marketing groups with names like California Milk Processor Board and MilkPEP hired ad agencies to fill America's TV screens, magazines, and toys with advertisements for milk. Enter "Got Milk?" their most famous ad campaign, which set out to do something as elusive as it was ambitious—to make milk cool.







The USDA Dietary Guidelines for Americans recommends two to three servings of dairy per day, and it's been that way for decades. But little do most people know, drinking fresh milk is a thoroughly modern phenomenon.

It wasn't until refrigeration and pasteurization brought fresh milk to the masses in the early 20th century that Americans drink milk without worrying about getting sick. Farmers began producing so much, in fact, that after World War II, there was a nationwide surplus. So the federal government got involved. It bought up excess milk, which wound up in government cheese and on cafeteria trays via the national school lunch program, created in 1946.

Fast-forward to the 1980s, to the Reagan era, and a free-market ideology had taken hold. There was little appetite for agricultural subsidies. Legislators began favoring a model they'd rolled out in the '30s with Florida citrus growers: taxing farmers to fund advertising campaigns.

GotMilk (1995 - 2010)







